

***The Child and the State in India:
Twenty Years Later***

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PAPER ABSTRACT: Twenty years ago, Myron Weiner described the laggard condition of mass education in India in a groundbreaking book, *The Child and the State in India*. Relative to other countries with similar economies, India trailed across almost every single educational measure. Weiner ascribed much of India's shortcomings in education to lack of governmental support from the leaders at the Centre, leaders whom he suspected would always resist improving mass education. Since the publication of Weiner's book, however, governmental support for Indian education has improved dramatically.

In this paper, I examine what influences national-level government support for social development in the developing world. I do so by examining why Indian national-level government officials have shown a serious commitment to mass education reform when they have historically refused to do so. More than rising incomes, ethnic considerations, or pressures from domestic business, I find evidence that international factors – such as foreign aid and the demands from international institutions such as the World Bank – have played a critical role in bringing education to the forefront of Indian politics.

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I. Introduction

In 1991, Myron Weiner published *The Child and the State in India* (Weiner 1991). In this stunning book, Weiner presented the abysmal status of mass education in India. While mass education had slowly improved since Independence in 1947, Weiner was struck by how poor the Indian education system remained. What was most puzzling for Weiner was that compared to countries of similar economic trajectories, the Indian education system still lagged far behind similar countries in all key measures. Also, while most other countries had enforced compulsory education laws before or shortly after undergoing industrialization, Indian government leaders at the national level were loath to adopt such policies in practice, or even in rhetoric. Weiner argued that this reluctance of the politicians and bureaucrats at the Centre to initiate mass education reform was a key impediment for improving the condition of education in India, and he was dour that the Centre would ever be serious about improving education.

As of 2011, the prospect of getting an education is much more promising for the average Indian child. National funding for mass education has increased substantially, in both relative and absolute terms, while the Centre has demonstrated a surprising willingness for creativity by implementing schemes such as the National Literacy Mission and Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA), the latter being the famous midday meals scheme that feeds millions of children every school day throughout India. In addition to increasing funding for mass education and implementing successful education schemes, Indian politicians at the Centre have further demonstrated their newfound support for education through Constitutional reform. In 2002, the government finally amended the Constitution to declare that children have a fundamental right to education. But the capstone to this generation of educational transformation came in the summer of 2009 with the unanimous passage of *The Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act*. This act finally committed the state to compulsory primary education and it had repeatedly failed to pass the Indian Parliament since the time of India's founding.¹

This turnaround in national-level governmental support seems to have had an effect. While several other factors doubtlessly affect educational outcomes in a multilayered system of governance such as India, national patterns suggest that on the whole, conditions are improving. According to the Indian census, adult literacy rates have increased from 52.22% in 1991 to

¹ It deserves noting that this act was rejected in a vote in 2004 and it was stalled in 2006. I have not yet uncovered why this predecessor bill was put to a vote in 2004. Especially in a parliamentary system, one would not expect a bill to be put to a vote unless the ruling agenda setters thought it could pass.

74.04% in 2011 (Indian Census 2011).² Over the same time period, youth literacy rates have risen from 61.9% to 82.1%.³ These advances are even more stunning when one considers that the Indian population has grown by about 360 million people since 1991, to more than 1.2 billion people as of 2011.⁴ Additionally, much of the improvement in educational performance has taken place where most models of public goods provision would tell us to least expect it: in India's poorest states; amongst minority communities (particularly Muslim communities); and perhaps most surprisingly, with females outpacing males over the time period. Government statistics and private surveys also indicate that school enrollment and attendance figures are at all-time highs.

For those who have read Myron Weiner's book, such improvements in education are tremendously heartening, but also come unexpected. For a variety of reasons that will be presented in the next section, Weiner was doubtful that government officials would support mass education. In this paper, I ask why national-level government commitment to mass education materialized in India after so long: why has there been such an amazing commitment to educational improvement over the past twenty years, and perhaps more interestingly, why have politicians now committed the state to ensuring compulsory education? To be clear, this paper is not about explaining educational performance in India to date, though I think national-level governmental support is crucial to understanding outcomes. Instead, I am investigating why government leaders choose to pursue specific social development agendas at certain times and not others. Specifically, I am interested in ascertaining why Centre-level support for mass education has only materialized since 1991.

One possibility is that the Indian constituency's demand for education has somehow changed in the past twenty years. In line with most models of democracy, we would expect that greater demand by citizens leads to greater supply from politicians: politicians should support education because their voters want it.⁵ In turn, politicians would make sure that other government officials improve the educational system. There are at least two reasons why we might expect such a shift in constituency demand. First, the Indian middle class has expanded

² From 1971-1991, literacy grew 17.2%; from 1991-2011, literacy increased by 21.82%.

³ Similar growth rates in Indian literacy are reported by UNESCO, who state that adult literacy rates have increased from 48.2% in 1991 to 66.0% in 2007.

⁴ In 1991, India had 866.5 million people (Indian Census Data, 1991-2011).

⁵ These models derive from Downs (1957), whose median-voter model predicts that elected officials will accede to the preferences of the voters. For a more detailed summary of these models in the context of India, please see Keefer and Khemani (2009).

considerably since 1991. With more disposable income, voters may now place greater value on education. Similarly, with more disposable income, voters may now be better positioned to make these demands known. Second, scholars of ethnic politics have shown that redistributive policies similar to educational expansion are likely to be thwarted when ethnic tensions are high. If ethnic tensions go down, Indian voters are more likely to support compulsory education, which is treated in this paper as an inherently liberal and redistributive policy.

Another separate possibility is that support for improving mass education has increased for reasons that are independent of the broad-based electorate. In Europe, it was the labor unions that pressured their officials to pass compulsory education laws. In East Asia, mass education was the product of industrialists and other business elites working closely with government technocrats. Perhaps something similar happened in India. Alternatively, Indian politicians may now be supporting education reform due to pressures that are external to India. International institutions such as UNESCO and the International Labor Organization have long pushed for compulsory education laws in India; perhaps their demands for education overhaul were conveyed in a novel manner that proved both persuasive and effective.

I find the most support for this last alternative: Indian national government officials are now supporting mass education reform because of international pressures, and especially because of the impact of international donor agencies. International donor agencies are giving unprecedented financial aid in support of Indian education reform. Moreover, there is some evidence which suggests that donors are channeling support for education directly through the Indian state, even as they fund other initiatives such as healthcare in manners designed to avoid the state. Such differences in patterns of funding would create incentives for Indian government officials to support education reform even as they fail to respond to other aspects of social development. Just as notable, Indian government officials are now much more likely to compare their country's educational performance with other countries' performance, to a degree that was not experienced before 1991. The increase in such comparisons suggests a process of competitive development, whereby Indian mass education is further supported because government officials want to compete with other countries.

In 1991, Myron Weiner was correct in recognizing that education would not improve without a change in national-level government support; today, this is no longer the problem with the Indian education system. But while education measures have improved considerably since

1991, the Indian education system still falls well short of realizing its full potential. I therefore close this paper by considering some of the factors which will form the biggest impediments to Indian educational improvement over the next twenty years. I argue that these impediments are now primarily at the state- and local-levels, where embezzlement and teacher absenteeism are thought to be rampant. This suggests the need for comparative investigations of sub-national educational policy and performance in the future.

II. 1947-1991: Limited Support for Education in India

“A correspondent asks:

‘Are you in favour of the introduction of a compulsory primary education system in India? Is it unjust or unnecessary to make this education compulsory? If we get *Swaraj* [self-governance] in the present condition of our country, will you make primary education compulsory throughout the whole of India?’

I fear I must answer the main question in the negative.”

Mohandas Gandhi wrote the preceding passage in a newspaper article in 1924 (Gandhi 1962, 25).⁶ A fierce liberal-progressive on other issues, Gandhi had a limited vision for the state’s role in education. Drawing on his own educational background and tying his beliefs to Indian political philosophy, Gandhi argued that Indian education should never be compulsory: children should learn because they want to learn, and the state should resist making any compulsory requirements demands on its citizens. Gandhi regularly downplayed the value of traditional education while extolling the virtues of learning through labor in other essays and speeches.⁷ Despite being a lawyer himself, Gandhi repeatedly said that learning how to read is not as important as learning a craft, and that the ideal classroom is one in which students are making cloth while listening to a teacher who is also gainfully multi-tasking. Gandhi even used issues such as compulsory education and British educational reform to galvanize Indians against the British. For instance, the Quit India movement encouraged students to stop attending schools in all areas where the British had made education compulsory.

While Gandhi was assassinated just one year after India achieved its independence from the British, his beliefs and his writings on education shaped the decisions of his political

⁶ Gandhi wrote several treatises on educational philosophy and politics. Gandhi was also very active in pre-Independence education politics, even heading the National Education Conference in 1924. Throughout his career, Gandhi stresses the value of non-traditional forms of education.

⁷ Gandhi argues that the state has the responsibility to provide education, but he is torn between concentrating control of the educational system in a national government or whether such control should be relegated to the states.

descendants. The Indian Constitution, for instance, is a manifest of otherwise-populist Gandhian ideals. Minimum wages are provided; equal rights are extended to citizens of differing religious and cultural beliefs; equal political and economic rights are also afforded to women, with provisions that would later be used to increase women's presence in politics. But in line with Gandhi's skeptical attitudes toward education, the parts of the Constitution regarding compulsory education were much more guarded.⁸ Thus Article 45 of the Constitution says that the state should merely endeavor to provide free and compulsory education to children in the future.⁹ Such wording is comparatively weak: knowing that the state could not enforce minimum wages or definitively protect the rights of minorities and women, the Constitution is unwavering in the guarantees it provides. But making universal education a political right is something which the founders chose to delay. Thus, unlike other topics of development, the puzzling problem of education at India's Independence was not about what the state could or could not provide, but it was instead about what government leaders thought the state should endeavor to provide.

Following the ratification and adoption of the Indian Constitution in 1950, the national government soon relegated most control of education policy to the states, some of which further ceded control to their localities. Many of the states had preexisting compulsory education laws from British rule, though only a few of these states chose to maintain these laws. So for instance, while Uttar Pradesh chose to maintain their British-era compulsory education laws, Madhya Pradesh repealed all such British-era education laws in 1961.¹⁰ Indeed, throughout much of the 1950s and 1960s, compulsory education laws were constantly under debate in state legislatures throughout India. According to Goprsh Ojha, at least a dozen states either passed compulsory education laws, struck such laws down, or did both between 1950 and 1965 (1966).

One might expect the state-level school systems to have been reeling from such legislative indeterminacies. At the time, however, these state-level laws had very little effects on actual educational implementation. This was for two reasons: first, many laws had little effect on implementation to begin with, and second, these compulsory education laws found so much

⁸ Gandhi was also a supporter of child labor. Partly as a result, the Constitution only bans child labor of certain forms (See Article 24 of the *Indian Constitution*, 1950). Children were only banned from working in mines and from other highly hazardous jobs. It should be noted that compulsory education is essentially a ban on child labor.

⁹ India, *Indian Constitution* (1950) Article 45: "The State shall endeavor to provide, within a period of ten years from the commencement of this Constitution, for free and compulsory education for all children until they complete the age of fourteen years."

¹⁰ See the Bihar and Orissa Primary Education Act of 1919 (Amended 1959) and the Madhya Pradesh Primary Education Act (1961).

resistance that the only way they would pass was if they were watered down to the point of being rendered futile. So for instance, the Mysore Compulsory Primary Education Act of 1961 merely reserves the right to make education compulsory in certain localities within the state.¹¹ The Tamil Nadu Elementary Education Act (as amended in 1973) makes it a requirement that the entire state legislature vote before education was made compulsory in any locality within the state. As a result, legally-mandated compulsory education was rarely attained, even when it had purportedly passed in state legislatures.¹² Despite some debate, state legislators proved unwilling to pass laws seriously requiring compulsory education. This was equally true with their counterparts in the Indian Parliament.

During this same time period, national officials proved equally hesitant to change education policy. Why were government officials at all levels so reluctant to improve education? As Weiner chronicles, elite-level resistance to education reform from 1947 to 1991 was consistently high. Beyond the influence of Gandhian ideology, Weiner found that Indian government officials – and especially politicians – were reticent to compare India with other countries. There was a powerful notion that the Indian political economy was so different from any other society that it did little good to compare India with other developing and developed countries. For instance, many in government argued that if children worked instead of attending school, impoverished families would receive some financial relief. Never mind that when other countries were faced with similar levels of poverty, they were able to ban child labor and impose compulsory education in its stead. Indeed, when Weiner informed officials that other countries were able to impose compulsory education even in the face of correspondingly high levels of poverty, Indian elites appeared indifferent, and even unashamed (1991). Instead, these *exceptionalists* explained how India was too unique to be compared with these other countries. These *exceptionalists* thought comparisons were fruitless as India had too many people, too much poverty, a Gandhian economy, and specific cultural norms. After 1991, this notion of *exceptionalism* went away, and it was only with the passage of the 2009 *Compulsory Education Act* that child labor was truly banned.

¹¹ More recent examples with almost identical wordings include the Karnataka Education Act (1983) and the Goa Compulsory Elementary Education Act (1995).

¹² There are some notable exceptions, such as a small region in Bihar and some localities in Maharashtra, where compulsory education had been on the books since the 1920s.

One of the byproducts of this *exceptionalist* perspective was that mass education reform was never recognized as something that would trigger economic growth. This viewpoint is profound considering the global environment of the 1970s and 1980s, when the Washington Consensus championed education as one of the building blocks for a healthy economy. Throughout this time period, however, mass education was seen as a redistributive policy, something better suited for addressing poverty-alleviation, not a project that would trigger economic growth. Since gaining Independence, Indian officials have regularly favored policies of economic growth over redistribution agendas.¹³ Consequently, these officials extolled the virtues of economic expansion, arguing that market supremacy would treat other socio-political imbalances such as poverty and illiteracy in due course (e.g., Bhagwati 1993). While such a modernization theory has long influenced development-thinking, this logic would especially come to the fore in the 1970s and 1980s. If economic growth and industrialization were to take place, the belief was that benefits would then trickle-down through society and poverty-reducing redistribution could then be achieved without government intervention. Education would improve once the economy increased.

While Indian officials were sympathetic to growth approaches, such approaches failed to address poverty as theory predicted: economic gains only slightly improved the conditions of India's impoverished by 1991. Ever suspicious of trickle-down economics and theories of modernization, Myron Weiner concluded his book by declaring that "universal schooling will not come with rising incomes" (1991, 205). By this statement, Weiner wanted to reject the dominant assumption at the time that growth for a few would automatically help everybody. Instead, Weiner persuasively argued that institutional reform was necessary, and this would only come about with national-level government support for education. Looking back, we can see that Weiner was right: economic growth without the right institutions seems to do little for alleviating poverty, especially in India (Kohli forthcoming), just as this economic growth would not have automatically spelled better educational achievement in India.

In summary, Indian national-level government officials prior to 1991 were reluctant to support mass education for three reasons. First, Gandhian ideology remained relevant, and this ideology rejected compulsory education and the value of literacy. Second was the pervasive

¹³ Indian national politicians typically pledge to seek both economic growth and poverty-reducing redistribution, but inequality has persisted even in the face of growth.

belief among government officials that India was *exceptional*: strategies that had worked for improving other countries would fail in India. Finally, government officials believed that it was more important to focus on economic growth first, and only with more economy could education be improved. It was believed that mass education was redistributive, not something that would trigger economic growth. But as will be shown, Indian officials have signaled their commitment to expanding education in recent years. What brought about this change? More generally, why do government leaders in developing countries choose to support providing public goods when they were previously reluctant to do so?

III. Sources for Support

From 1947 until at least 1991, Indian government officials were reluctant to support mass education. Since then, Centre-level support for education has soared. What brought about this change? More generally, why do government leaders in developing countries choose to provide public goods when they were previously reluctant to do so? I will consider four hypotheses as to why Indian national leaders have begun to support mass education. First, perhaps an emerging middle class has been able to generate demands on the respective state and national governments through democratic means. Due to new needs or values that come with affluence, voters may have pressured government officials (and particularly politicians) to initiate mass education reform. While Weiner was skeptical that such rising incomes could transform government support for mass education, such a theory should be considered, particularly given the growth of the middle-class since 1991.¹⁴

A second compelling hypothesis is that ethnic tensions may have declined, promoting liberal sentiments, which in turn spurred redistribution initiatives such as education. There are two reasons as to why ethnic tensions might slow support for education. The first is highlighted by Ashutosh Varshney in his study of the ways in which ethnic divides have impeded Indian poverty alleviation and social development in the past (1995). Varshney argues that ethnic divides split voters who should be working together for the same policies and reforms. Without these divides, the poor voters would be better able to pressure their elected officials for services that they want. The second way in which ethnic tensions might affect redistributive measures

¹⁴ There is some debate about whether India's economic growth started in 1980, with the re-introduction of Indira Gandhi, or in 1991, with liberalization. See Rodrik and Subramanian (2004) and Panagariya (2008).

such as education is by shaping prejudices on the part of government officials. Evan Lieberman finds that the level of ethnic boundaries not only affects the performance of local governments' response to the HIV/AIDS epidemic in India, but that ethnic boundaries also shape the attitudes of the local politicians' responses to the disease (2009). For education, government officials might believe that it is a waste of resources to educate a member of an untouchable caste or to educate Muslims when ethnic tensions are high. Since education has improved amongst untouchables and Muslims especially since 1991, such an ethnic hypothesis means that there either should have been a change in the national discourse regarding ethnic boundaries or certain Indian states with lower ethnic boundaries should be disproportionately carrying the improvement in mass education.¹⁵

A third hypothesis is that education reform has been generated by the demands of industrialization and a transforming economy. In industrializing Europe, the push to improve education came from worker unions and factories. They successfully persuaded politicians to enforce laws banning child labor, thereby making education compulsory. Outside of Europe, Alice Amsden and others have discussed how government elites and industrialists together identified mass education to be a critical factor for Taiwan's and South Korea's industrialization (Amsden 1989; Papenek 1988). While Indian government officials have not traditionally identified mass education as useful for economic growth, perhaps industrialists and business elites were able to convince the Centre that mass education was necessary. The troubling part for this hypothesis is the timing: either business leaders suddenly wanted mass education in 1991 or they suddenly achieved access to the Centre that they did not enjoy previously. If the former mechanism were true, educational improvement should be taking place in states which have undergone industrialization. If the latter mechanism were true, there should be evidence that the Centre is under increasing influence of industry. Either dynamic could have been at play in India over the past several years.¹⁶

It is also worth considering whether governmental support for education reform has emerged due to international pressures. International actors such as institutions, NGOs, and other

¹⁵ India is ethno-linguistically divided along state lines. There are other ethnic divides, however, including caste divides, religious divides, and racial divides. For an excellent essay on whether ethnic identity needs to be re-examined, see Chandra (2006).

¹⁶ A leading industrialist, Jamsetji Nusserwanji Tata, was the driving force behind the Indian Institute of Science. See the Indian Institute of Science website: <http://www.iisc.ernet.in/> (Last accessed January 11, 2010). Despite a voluminous number of studies on the effects of the Indian higher education system, the history of Indian higher education remains understudied.

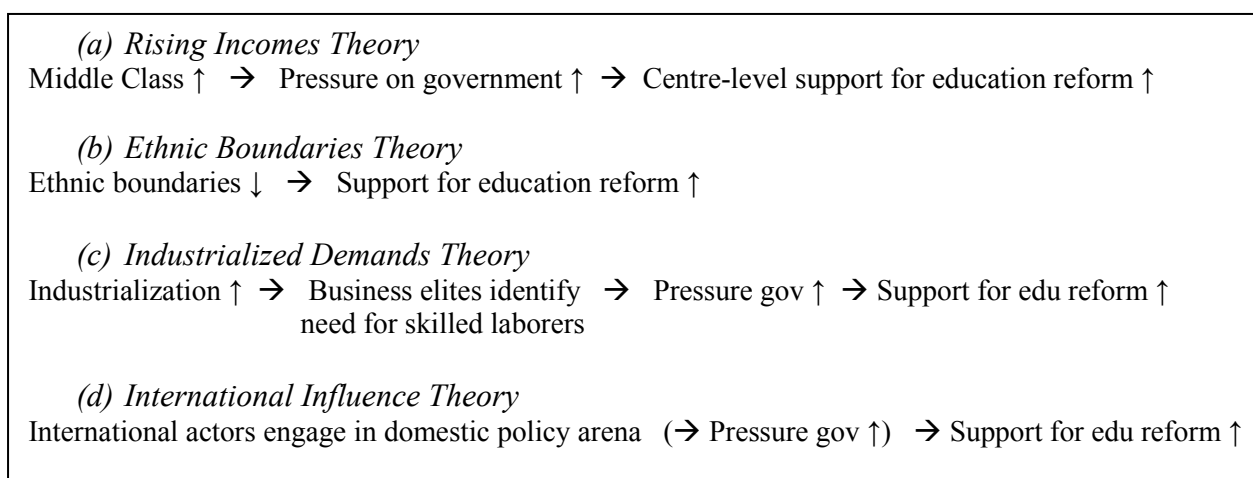


Figure 1: Four Hypotheses Explaining Change of Governmental Support for Mass Education Reform

nations have historically worked hard to convince the Centre to improve educational standards (Kapur, Lewis and Webb 1993; Kohli 1989, 78). While the Centre has historically been reluctant for the reasons mentioned above, it is plausible that the international community has managed to have a greater influence in Indian politics than they had before 1991. For such an international influence theory to be credible, we should observe educational improvement across the country, regardless of the demands of the electorate, ethnic divisions, or industrial conditions. An increasing level of international engagement would also be required to substantiate this hypothesis. These four hypotheses are presented schematically in Figure 1.

Before continuing it is worth dismissing another potential hypothesis, one that appears inadequate for explaining why Indian government officials have chosen to support education. This has to do with the nature of supplying education itself. Education is a non-tangible public good requiring several hundreds of thousands of teachers to be appointed. It is perfect for corruption. The nefarious hypothesis as to why national-level Indian government officials are supporting education has to do with the fact that bribery and corruption could be most easily conducted in this sector. By expanding mass education, government officials might be able to steal resources, and indeed, there is plenty of evidence that corruption in education is “big business” (Heyneman 2004, 641). It could be the case that support for mass education has come about because it is easy for government officials to be corrupt.

Unfortunately, we have no evidence as to whether corruption has increased or decreased since 1991. But a recent Transparency-International survey asked below-the-poverty-line (BPL)

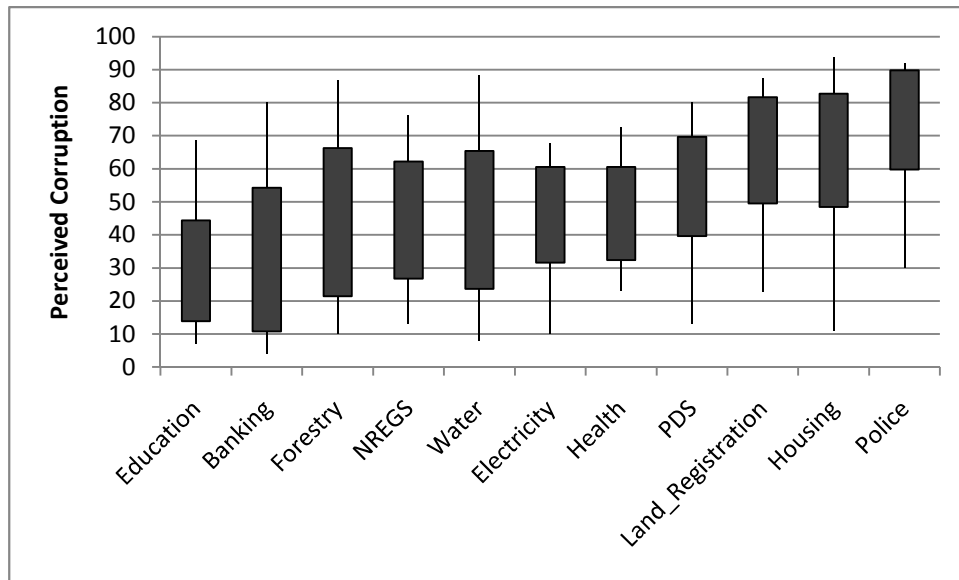


Figure 2: Perceived Corruption across Service Sectors in India (Data from TII-CMS Survey 2008)

respondents to compare perceived corruption across different government sectors. BPL respondents form a politically-marginalized group in society, suggesting that they should ordinarily experience the most corruption of anyone. As shown in Figure 2, the level of perceived corruption in education is far lower than it is across comparable government service sectors (TII-CMS Survey 2008).¹⁷ This data suggests that national-level government support for Indian education is real: it is not merely the result of public officials seeking to abuse their offices for private gain.

IV. Educational Performance and Reform in Post-Independence India

When the British left India in 1947, about 20% of the population was literate. More than forty years later, the national level of literacy was estimated at 48% in 1991. By 2011, the literacy rate was 74.04%.¹⁸ Non-government statistics are equally impressive. According to the National Family Health Survey, the percentage of women without any education had gone down

¹⁷ I have compiled this data for a separate paper in which I compare perceived corruption between states versus across government sectors. It seems as though corruption varies more across government sectors than it does between Indian states, suggesting the need for political scientists to compare government sectors as well as states.

¹⁸ UNESCO shows an almost 20% growth in literacy from 1991-2007; Government of India statistics show a 13% growth in literacy from 1991-2001 alone; other government statistics claim that since then, another 120 million people have become literate through the National Literacy Mission while school attendance has increased between 10-20%.

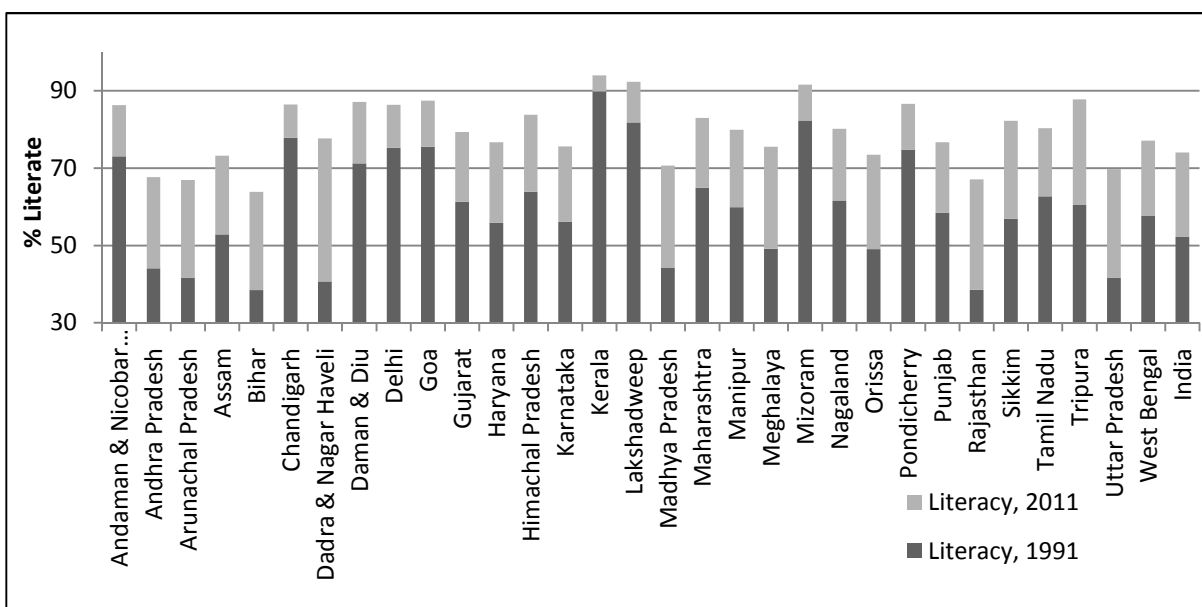


Figure 3: Literacy Change by States in India, 1991-2011 (Data from RBI 2011)

from 54.7% to 41.5% between 1992 and 2006, while the percentage of men without any education had dropped from 29.2% to 21.9% over the same time period. These improvements seem to have occurred across the country, not just in certain areas.¹⁹ In Figure 3, literacy rates are presented by states and union territories in 1991 and in 2011. Unlike several other redistributive policies in Indian history, this remarkable improvement in literacy has been widespread: apart from Kerala and the union territories of Mizoram and Chandigarh which all had high literacy rates to begin with, every state and union territory improved its literacy rate by double digits.

The increase in literacy is due in no small part to the National Literacy Mission (NLM), created in 1993.²⁰ The NLM is a joint program between UNESCO and the Indian government. More than 10 million Indians were recruited to improve the nation's literacy. According to government statistics, the NLM had made 118 million Indians literate across India by March of 2005: approximately 10% of India's current population.²¹

¹⁹ I have not yet properly analyzed the National Family Health Survey data by state, but I expect to find a similar trend in state-wide educational improvement.

²⁰ Also in 1993, the Supreme Court ruled for providing compulsory education in *Unnikrishnan vs. Andhra Pradesh*. The Supreme Court may have played a role in affecting politicians' support for mass education, but more research needs to be done. It nevertheless should be stressed that the Supreme Court has ruled on the necessity of providing other public goods without receiving the same response from elected leaders.

²¹ Though it is not included in this paper, I am happy to share a table I have compiled showing which states and districts have benefited the most from the NLM. No region jumps out: the NLM seems to have been implemented relatively evenly across the country (NLM 2010).

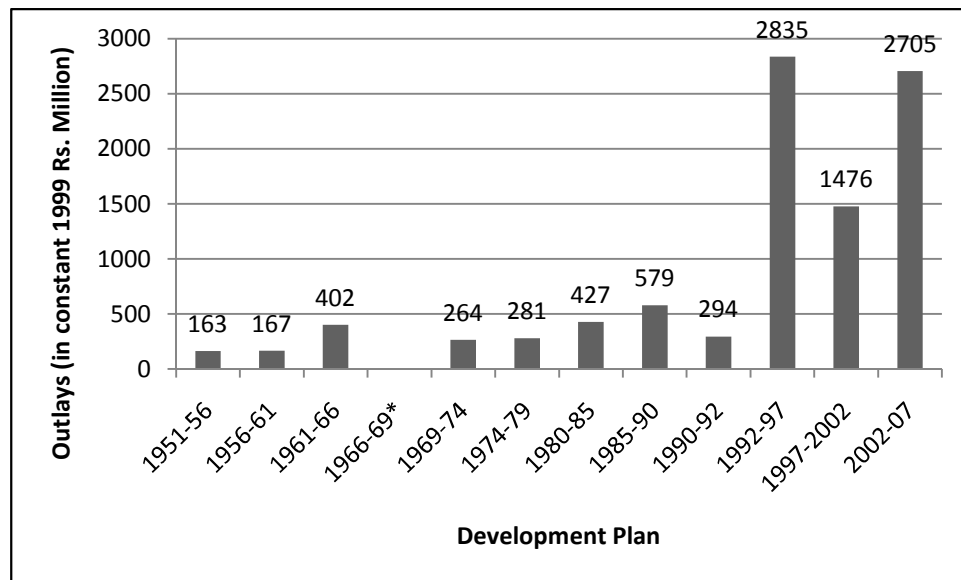


Figure 4: Outlays for Elementary Education Spending, by *Five Year National Plans*, in constant Rs. Million (Author's compilation of data from *National Plans*)

While different factors may explain why some states have slightly outperformed others, the distributed and relatively even improvement across all states suggests that national-level commitment to education has played an important role in India's literacy successes.²² Unlike the past when national politicians merely promised to improve the condition of the average Indian, recent commitment to education has come with real financing. The amount of money to be allocated from the national government for state spending is typically set according to a Five Year Plan. In Figure 4, federal outlays for elementary education over the first eleven *Five Year National Plans* are shown.²³ From 1950-1990, the rates of spending on elementary education were relatively constant. As Weiner stresses, these rates of spending were well below that of other developing countries when controlled for economic growth (1991). But while spending remained constant, India's population doubled. It should therefore come as little surprise that

²² I ran some basic correlations for literacy improvement and GDP per capita by state. Literacy improvement was greatest in some of the poorest states. While there is something of a "ceiling effect," meaning that states with high literacy are unlikely to improve compared with states with low literacy, it is clear that poorer states have also enjoyed improvements in education. Figure 7 features a graph of the National Literacy Mission's performance by state, relative to GDP.

²³ Author's compilation from *India's National Plans*; deflator comes from UN Data. There was no National Plan during the period 1966-1969. There was also no National Plan over the 1990-1992 period, but the subsequent National Plan reported outlays. The outlays are only for those two years, whereas the outlays indicated by other plans are for 5 years.

expenditure per student had actually declined in real terms between 1951 and 1985 (Ministry of Education 1985). From 1992 onwards, elementary education outlays grew substantially.

Reading the *National Plans* over this time period is equally revealing.²⁴ The *National Plans* from 1947-1992 discuss education categorically, almost as a required after-thought on a laundry list of state functions. Beginning with the *1992-1997 National Plan*, improving education becomes a national prerogative. Education features prominently throughout the whole report, and it is pitched as a way of improving economic growth while reducing poverty. International cooperation for improving education is first mentioned in the *2002-2007 National Plan*. Indeed, international funding for education seems to have caused the *2002-2007 National Plan* to have a mid-plan revision of estimates on education spending. These revisions, which are not shown in Figure 4, increased spending by approximately 70% to about 4,600 million rupees.²⁵ The *2007-2012 National Plan* is currently in force. Data on Indian government spending for primary education could not be identified in this report because there was no specification between Indian government outlays and international spending, suggesting increased cooperation between the government and international agencies. Also, the financing for education currently in the *2007-2012 National Plan* is expected to be revised shortly. In the last financial cycle, education spending as a percentage of GDP was slightly under 4%. Both the Congress Party and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) have stated in their national platforms that they intend to raise education spending to 6% of the Indian GDP by 2012 (Congress 2009; BJP 2010).²⁶

Since 1991, Centre-level support for mass education and for compulsory education in particular has clearly emerged, as evidenced by the significant increase in education funding. In 2002, the ruling BJP passed a Constitutional amendment re-asserting the right for the Indian Parliament to make compulsory education laws. However, despite proposing a compulsory

²⁴ A comprehensive textual analysis of India's *5 Year National Plans* would be a fruitful next step for this project. From reading the *National Plans*, India's commitment to education begins to flourish in the *1992-1997 Plan*, and international cooperation in education is first mentioned in the *2002-2007 Plan*. The *2007-2012 Plan* is currently in force; I did not include data from it because there were so many mentions of international programs that I could not find data on how much money the Indian government was spending itself.

²⁵ National plans not only report projected outlays, but also show expenditures during the previous periods. The actual expenditure for 2002-2007 was found by examining the *2007-2012 National Plan*.

²⁶ The word "education" appears 24 times in the Congress Party *Manifesto*, while "health" is mentioned 9 times. The BJP's *Manifesto* is even more pronounced, with support of mass education frequenting the entire document. For comparison, improving healthcare is mentioned toward the bottom of the BJP *Manifesto*, next to climate change.

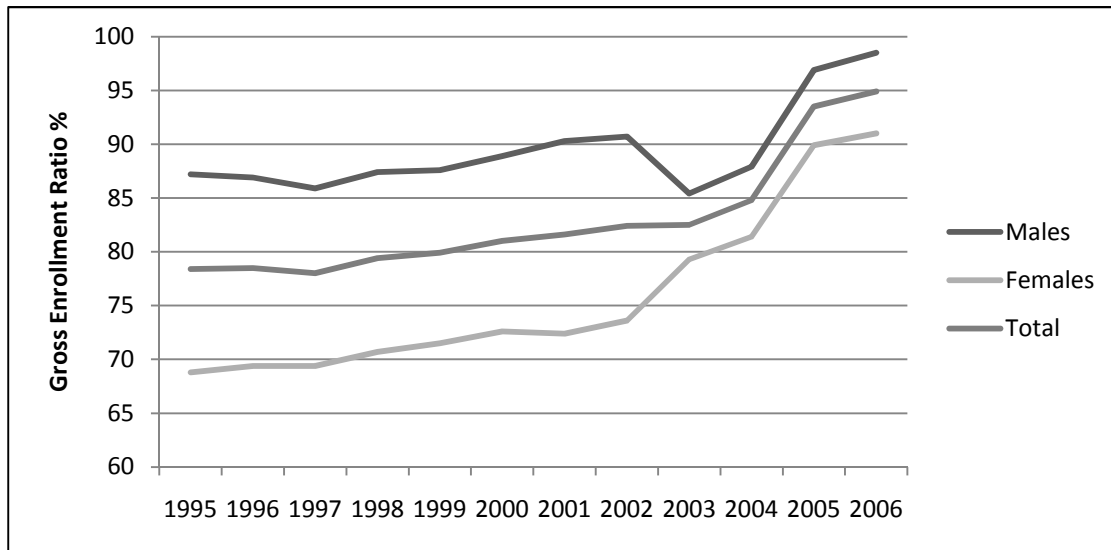


Figure 5: Gross Enrollment Ratios for India, 1995-2006 (Data from RBI 2010)

education bill shortly afterward, the BJP failed to pass any such act before surrendering national power to the Congress Party in 2004.²⁷ While the BJP was unable to pass a law requiring compulsory education, in 2001 they created a flagship educational initiative called Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA, literally “Education for All”). The goal of the SSA is to bring about the conditions favorable to compulsory education, with many of its projects specifically focused on the poorest classes in society. The SSA is perhaps most well-known for the midday meal program, where, in order to increase school attendance and to improve childhood nutrition, primary schools now offer free midday meals.²⁸ After the Congress Party took control of government in 2004, they decided to expand the SSA. According to the Congress Party Platform, the midday meal program now feeds 150 million children every day (2009).

Figure 5 shows the effect of the midday meals program on the gross enrollment ratio of children in primary schools. This ratio is the number of children enrolled in primary school divided by the number of children of primary age. It is also one of the measures used to calculate

²⁷ *The Right to Education Bill* of 2002 would have made education compulsory. Why this bill failed to pass after being introduced is worthy of more research, particularly since bills in Parliamentary systems do not usually fail once they have been introduced, depending on the agenda control. George Tsebelis calls for similar research investigating the relationship between agenda control and the number of veto players (2002, 186). Unfortunately, voting records for the Indian Parliament are not easily accessible.

²⁸ The midday meal plan seems to have first been implemented in the former state of Madras in 1956, with the intention of increasing school participation (Ojha 1966, 270).

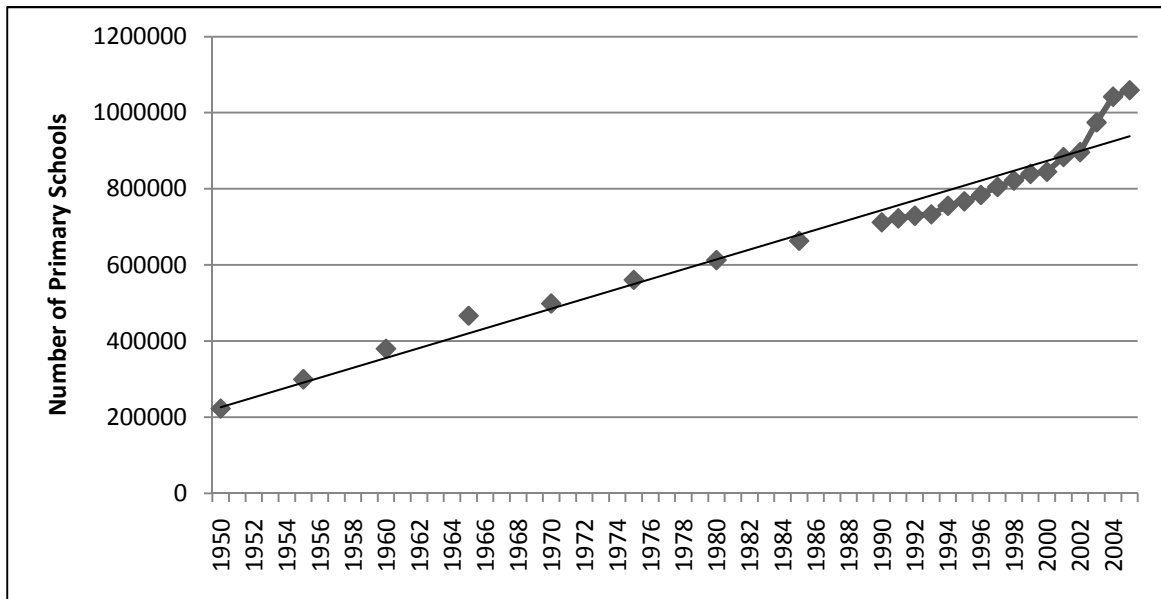


Figure 6: Number of Government Primary Schools in India, 1950-2005 (Data from RBI 2010)

the UN Human Development Index. This ratio has risen steadily since SSA was introduced.²⁹ While the SSA has been heavily supported by the Indian government, international actors are also taking part in funding the SSA. In 2008, the British government authorized £150 million (approximately Rs. 12 billion) for the SSA program from 2008-2010. Since 2003, the British government has donated or pledged £500 million for mass education programs in India, frequently targeting impoverished states such as Bihar and Madhya Pradesh (IANS 2008).

Almost all of the £500 million in grants given by the British government for education have been given directly to Indian government-initiated programs. In contrast, British aid for healthcare has frequently circumvented the state as the DFID has created their own offices and partnered directly with hospitals rather than with the state. For education, the British government has given money to state programs to encourage the expansion of the primary school system. In Figure 6, I present the number of government primary schools in India over time, a measure often used to proxy educational access. I have included an estimator line to highlight the increase in primary schools since 2001. Indeed, by 2005, almost 20% of all primary schools had been

²⁹ I do not know why the gross enrollment ratio of males dropped from 2001-2003. I suspect that these numbers do not reflect actual change, but were instead doctored to conform to political demands. Therefore while this chart does not necessarily accurately reflect improvement in education, it is plausible to view the trends in this chart as indicative of a shift in political framing of education, which is equally telling for my argument.

created in the previous four years. Many of these schools were created under the District Primary Education Program, another joint initiative between the government of India and international donors. In this case, the World Bank has been the largest external donor, but several other donors have also been involved. While the World Bank does not yet have data on the impact of this project, they suggest that as a result of this initiative, the number of Indian children out of school has lowered from 25 million in 2003 to about 7 million in 2006 (2010).

Other measures of Indian mass education show similar positive trends, signaling marked reforms in recent years.³⁰ These reforms have taken place across the country, targeting poor and rural citizens especially. And even though some of the improvements in literacy and education might be explained by a possible growth of the private school industry, national governmental support for education is undeniable. More than ever before, Indian officials are committed to reforming mass education, and they have shown a surprising resolve for compulsory education.

V. Assessing the Theories of Change

Since 1991, educational reform in India has been impressive. The numbers show that, perhaps for the first time in India's history, a government sector with real implications for the poor is experiencing some modicum of national-level success. During this same time period, we have observed an equally remarkable transformation, where Indian officials are actually supporting compulsory education, which they have long resisted. And also for the first time in history, Indian government officials are not only calling for education reform, but they are also seriously funding this reform. I now turn to analyzing why government leaders are now supporting mass education.

*A. Rising Incomes*³¹

There is little to suggest that the middle class has been a primary driver in affecting the Centre's stances on education. While the middle class has grown over the past generation, it is still very small. For a country of more than 1.1 billion people, the Indian middle class was

³⁰ I examined state-wise and national data on education spending, literacy, school attendance, and schools constructed, in addition to researching several specific initiatives.

³¹ There are actually two hypotheses as to how rising incomes affect political support for education. First, it could be that as certain citizens get richer, they demand more education. If many people in India have gotten to an economic level where they need education in India to further advance, then they will pressure their government. The second hypothesis is that the middle-class creates demands for better education. I have focused on the second in this section.

estimated to be about 50 million people in 2005 (McKinsey 2007).³² As a result, the middle class does not form a very strong voting bank. Therefore if the middle class is having an impact on Indian government, it is probably not through the some sort of median-voter channel of democracy.

While there are other non-democratic channels for affecting political change, it is not apparent why the middle class would seek education reform in the first place. If anything, the Indian middle class has possibly hampered expanding education for the poorer classes. Projects that address poverty and reduce inequality have historically received little support from the Indian middle class, and especially the urban middle class (Varshney 1995). The reasoning behind this lack of support is both interest- and ideologically-driven. In terms of interests, the children of the middle class already tend to have access to well-constructed schools with quality teachers. Given that most of the middle class lives in cities, there are usually plenty of substitute private schools. Rather than advocating for improved mass education, we would expect the Indian middle class to demand other services from their politicians. Such demands might include improved roads for personal vehicles, cleaner cities, and better urban transportation.

In terms of ideology, those in the Indian middle class have traditionally sought to distance themselves from the lower classes. Fernandes and Heller suggest that not much has changed with the new middle class. They find that the new middle class still strives to differentiate themselves from citizens in lower classes (2006). Whether it is due to interests or ideology, the middle class has been – and continues to be – reticent to support lower class political causes such as mass education. They cannot be the source behind why the Centre now supports mass education.

B. Ethnic Boundaries

Even if the median Indian voter is not demanding educational improvement because of rising incomes, it is plausible that ethnic politics have changed in such a way as to increase support of liberal programs such as mass education over the past twenty years. Contradicting this theory, however, is the fact that ethnic tensions have remained high at both the state and national levels, even as we have observed expansions in the education system. As Lieberman

³² The middle class is defined in terms of their disposable income. This report focuses on the growth of the Indian consumer market. Like development reports from the 1970s and 1980s, this report suggests that as long as economic growth is constant, poverty and economic inequality will shrink in the next twenty years. The report totally fails to account for the political factors necessary to make economic growth have such an effect.

demonstrates, ethnic tensions have remained high in India have made it unlikely that politicians will support equity-based public goods provision such as those required to respond to the HIV/AIDS epidemic (2009). But despite constantly high ethnic boundaries, India has nevertheless achieved tremendous advances in mass education, and these tremendous advances have been enabled by elected officials.³³

While a reduction in ethnic boundaries did not lead to governmental support for educational improvement, it could be the case that expanding education is a way of furthering high ethnic boundaries. When the Congress Party returned to power in 2004, one of its first acts was to put together a panel of historians to review changes made to history textbooks during the BJP administration (Ramesh 2004). The historians reported that a *saffronization* of history had taken place under the BJP government. Textbooks cast the Muslim rulers of India as pillaging invaders while glossing over the sordid history of the Hindu nationalist movement. It is possible that the BJP's seemingly-noble attempts to expand education reform may have resonated very well with those who sought to inflate existing ethnic divides. But whether or not educational reform was initially supported by those who sought to polarize ethnic divisions, compulsory education measures were passed resoundingly by both Houses of Parliament in 2009, well after the Hindu nationalist parties had left power.³⁴ Furthermore, Muslim communities and scheduled / backwards castes have been specifically targeted by the several education initiatives, while international institutions have especially demanded the improvement in the educational standing of these disenfranchised groups. Indeed, much of the improvements in education provision have happened in areas with large minority populations. When considered in the context of mass education reform, this ethnic boundary theory generates more questions than it explains.

Before moving on, it is worth examining traditional median voter theories more generally. Like other median voter theories, the rising incomes theory and the ethnic boundaries theory both rely on a shift in citizens' demands bringing about changes among politicians, or a shift in the citizens' collective ability to communicate their demands to the politicians. If we were to see such shifts, we would expect politicians to support reform in other sectors that provide public goods as well as education. For instance, we should expect healthcare reform and

³³ Examining sociotropic sentiments more generally, one can look at the World Values Survey from 1990 and 2001. When respondents were asked if most people can be trusted, 34.9% agreed in 1990, compared with 38.9% agreeing in 2001. This increase is small, suggesting that ethnic lines have remained constant during this time period (WVS, 2009).

³⁴ This will be the subject of another paper.

infrastructural improvement in rural areas (where most citizens are located) to be supported along with the expansion in mass education. Unfortunately, education improvement has been anomalous when compared with other public goods sectors. Paul, et al. recently conducted an analysis comparing public services across India's states (2004). They find that primary education and the state's improved ability to provide drinking water are two services that have improved in terms of access for the poor. Other services that are in high public demand, including healthcare, transportation infrastructure, and public rationing systems have actually become *less accessible* to the poor in recent years. This failure to improve other sectors suggests that citizens' calls for redistribution have remained relatively constant: Indian politicians are not expanding education in response to the demands of some new median voter.

C. Industrialized Demands

Business elites and industrialists have historically wielded much influence over the Indian development project. Following Independence, Vivek Chibber discusses how a campaign led by Indian industrialists prevented the formation of a strong development state (2006). Chibber argues that these industrialists sought benefits without regulations: they were able to demand trade protection and get the government to create the Indian Institutes of Technology, which have supplied corporations for years with talented engineers. As a result of kowtowing to these powerful interests, the Indian government never imposed the harsh steps necessary for industrialization. Given what we know about industrialization and knowledge economies, we should expect that these influential leaders have been a greater push for mass education in their localities. But despite the tremendous political power wielded by industrialists, they are not using this power to expand mass education. If industrialists were to be driving political change, we would expect educational improvement to be taking place in industrialized areas more so than in other areas. In Figure 7, the state domestic industrial product per capita is compared to the number of people made literate per capita under the NLM, by state. The correlation between industrialization and India's main literacy program is negligible (-0.03).

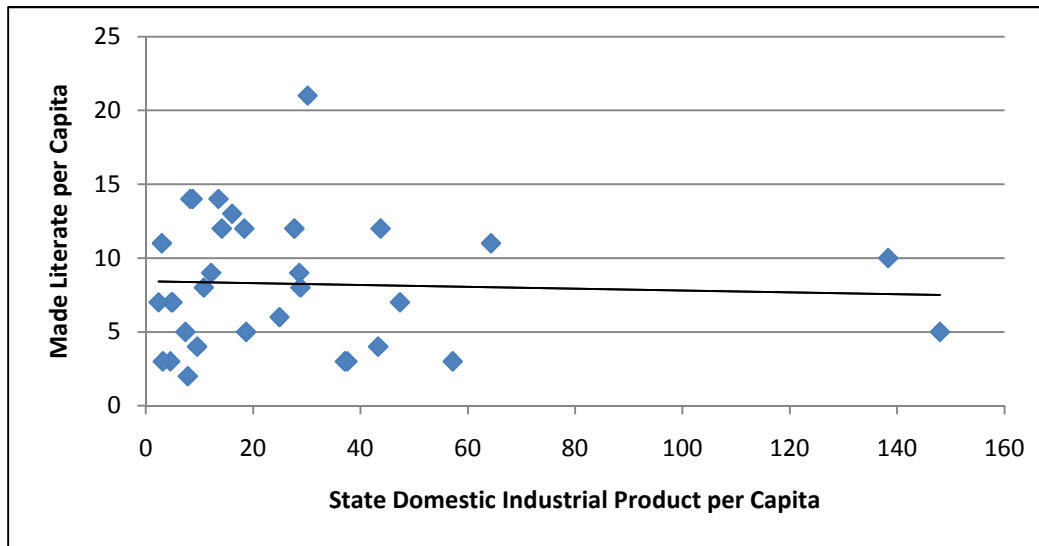


Figure 7: State Domestic Industrial Product Per Capita Vs. NLM's Made Literate Per Capita (Data from GoI-MHRD 2010)

From the figure, it seems as though industry elites do not seem to be agitating for mass education expansion in their states. This makes intuitive sense: companies either require their workers to perform labor-intensive tasks that do not require much education or they rely on highly-educated workers. Given the sophisticated nature of the contemporary global workplace, we would expect most industrialists to push for changes to higher education rather than for mass education reform. Indeed, industrialists seem to be much more engaged in the politics of higher education. By way of anecdotal evidence, consider Wipro Systems, India's largest information technology company. Wipro has identified that in order to succeed in the future, it needs to be able to draw from a larger pool of Indian engineers. Consequently, it recently created a program called Mission 10X, an aggressive program designed to improve domestic engineering education. At least 83 million USD have been put into the program.³⁵ Wipro has also been in talks with the Union Education Ministry to reform the engineering curriculum (*The Hindu* 2007). In contrast, Azim Premji, the Chairman of Wipro, recently wrote that improving mass education improves equity, which is beneficial for society. He did not recognize mass education as something beneficial to his company's success. As a result, it is hard to imagine Premji or Wipro pressuring the government to change mass education policy in the way that they are pushing for

³⁵ This is the amount of money Wipro has committed to the Maharashtra Institute of Technology, according to a Memorandum of Understanding signed in 2007 (Business Wire 2007). Wipro has also signed memorandums of understanding with several other Indian universities.

engineering education reform.³⁶ Such an industrialized demands theory does not seem to explain why politicians have increasingly expanded mass education systems.

D. International Engagement and Influence

Centre-level support for mass education has increased considerably in recent years, as has India's mass educational performance. States across India have made gigantic strides towards increasing literacy and they have made noteworthy steps in improving access to education. Potential domestic factors such as the emerging middle class, changes in ethnic politics, and transformations due to industrialization all do not seem to explain the change in Centre-level support for education. This leaves us with the possibility that international pressures have influenced government support for mass education reform.

While international actors have a pockmarked history in development, and particularly in Indian development, their influence has certainly shaped non-education policies in the past.³⁷ For example, Atul Kohli recognizes that during the Indian food shortages in the 1960s, "the Indian leadership...succumbed to external pressures. Aid was thus accepted with a commitment to treat production and growth as priority goals within the agrarian policy" (1989, 78). These external pressures were brought on by other nations and the FAO. In countless other arenas of politics, India's government officials have been willing to adopt the advice of foreign contingents, and especially the advice offered by certain organizations.

But international pressures for mass education reform have historically not been well-received by Indian officials. UNESCO has been regularly advocating for compulsory education in India since the 1950s, while an often-forgotten component of the Washington Consensus is the stress on improving education (Williamson 2000).³⁸ Prior to 1991, these calls for improving education were often deflected by the claim of Indian *exceptionalism*. Weiner chronicles a number of politicians and bureaucrats whose justification for India's poor record on education (and child labor) is that India is inherently different from other countries. It therefore did not matter that India was spending a smaller percentage of its GDP on education than corresponding

³⁶ To his credit, Premji has personally invested huge sums of money on mass education reform, but his initiative seems to be much more altruistic than selfish, and he has taken a hostile position to the Centre.

³⁷ For a review of the rocky history of international actors in development, see Chang (2003).

³⁸ John Williamson is the father of the term, "Washington Consensus." He observed that development institutions based in Washington DC (including the World Bank) were advocating similar policies. These policies included investments in human capital and primary education in particular (252).

developing countries, nor did it matter that India had one of the largest illiterate populations in the world: Indian leaders possessed a fervent belief that India could not be properly compared to other states, and that they did not need to prize “foreign” education targets such as literacy and school attendance. International calls for education reform were routinely rejected.

More recently, this position of Indian *exceptionalism* seems to have dissolved from the political discourse on education reform. For instance, during the debate on *The Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act* of 2009, Parliamentarians mention India’s obligation to provide education under the UN Declaration of Human Rights and under the UNESCO Convention against Discrimination in Education. Another parliamentarian mentions that “[t]he world is looking upon India in the hope that we would meet our national aspirations” (Lok Sabha 2009).³⁹ Clearly Indian politicians have become more receptive to international concerns for education reform.

What is driving this shift from *exceptionalism* towards competitive development? Certainly there has been a broad ideational shift in terms of how Indian government officials compare their country with the rest of the world, and this deserves much further study. At the same time, there seems to be powerful material incentives for government officials to support education reform. The international influences affecting the Centre’s support for mass education can take many different forms, but one of the clearest modicums of influence takes the form of international aid. International donor funding for Centre-led education started to grow around 1993 and dramatically ballooned around 2004.⁴⁰ In Table 1, I present the funding of various national schemes for mass education expansion from 2002-2007 (GoI-HRD 2010). The top schemes are funded domestically, while the bottom schemes are all funded through international support. Most of the international aid has come with the Indian government being expected to contribute as well. To indicate the domestic-international relationship, the internal and external funding of the SSA has also been highlighted in Table 1. Notice how the outlays for the SSA are first revised in 2004-2005, when the program is essentially doubled. Also notice how the Centre’s commitment to the SSA comes just as international actors increase their own investments in the same program. Such a commitment by the Centre may serve as a signaling

³⁹ The discourse of the Rajya Sabha is not available online, nor is the voting records of the Rajya and Lok Sabhas.

⁴⁰ The World Bank authorized the Indian District Primary Education Project in 1993. Prior to 1993, several international religious organizations invested considerably in Indian education. Of particular note were the Anglican and Catholic churches, which founded schools across India.

device or it may be a prerequisite for increased aid. While the donors are not indicated on the table, they include Great Britain's Department for International Development, the World Bank, the Asian Development Bank, UNICEF, the UN Development Programme, the International Labor Organization, USAID, and the European Commission.

From 2003 onwards, international actors have allocated tens of billions of rupees to state-administered programs aimed at achieving compulsory education in India by 2010.⁴¹ As their domestic outlays are essentially being met with hefty international contributions, there are real incentives for Indian national-level government officials to support mass education. Such large amounts of aid especially provide incentives for the government to pass laws encouraging compulsory education as international donors have continuously pressed for such laws. It seems as though international aid has proven to be a very good motivator for influencing government officials and for reforming Indian education, especially in recent years.

V. A Re-written Ending?

Myron Weiner concludes *The Child and the State in India* by writing:

“One is then left with the pessimistic conclusion that barring a conceptual change in the thinking of those who make and implement policy, and a new direction in policy by the Indian government, the number of children in the labor force will not significantly decline, conditions for working children will not significantly improve, school retention rates will not significantly increase, and literacy rates will continue to grow at a slow pace and will leave a large part of the Indian population illiterate well into the middle of the twenty-first century. With illiteracy and child labor declining world wide at a faster rate than in India, India's global share of illiterates and child laborers will continue to increase” (1991, 207).

Fortunately for India's poor, just such a conceptual change in thinking has taken place. No longer does a Gandhian ideology nor do notions of India's *exceptionalism* discourage education reform; indeed, it appears as though education is now considered a necessity for economic growth by government officials at the Centre. The roots of this change seems to have been borne from international pressures: even though Indian government officials were reluctant to listen to the international community when it advised them in the 1970s, it seems as though these same government officials have been willing to listen to the international community as it

⁴¹ As mentioned earlier, the British government and the World Bank made substantial contributions to the program in 2008.

advises mass education reform. Creating Centre-level support for mass education seems to have been a result of an ideological shift in how Indian government officials see their country in the world order, and it has also come due to huge financial investments by international actors. While this transformation has not been easy, it seems to be paying huge dividends: India is shrinking its illiterate population and it is making education available to the poor like never before.

If international actors have the power to overcome pervasive ideologies by getting Indian politicians to commit to expanding education, it is conceivable that these actors could increase Indian political support for anti-poverty programs more generally. On this point, it is important to recognize that the ways in which international influence is exerted may have differential effects. Not all international actions will generate Centre-level support.⁴² For instance, UNESCO has encouraged compulsory education since the 1950s, but Indian politicians rejected compulsory education until recently (Ojha, 1966). Similarly, in other poverty-related sectors, international actors have provided significant outlays for reform, but international agencies have not enjoyed the same success in Centre-level support. While international donors support many development programs, what perhaps makes the aid donations for Indian education unique from other international programs is the stunning absence of funding for NGOs and civil society organizations (CSOs). UNESCO itself has changed its mode of influence in recent years. Previously, the ways in which UNESCO sought to affect political support for compulsory education was by sponsoring various studies and non-governmental advocacy organizations. Now, UNESCO funds state programs for compulsory education directly. This pattern has emerged in two international donor reports for Indian education, the donating organizations both stressed the importance of funding state-run programs directly (Heath 2006; ADB 2010).⁴³ In contrast, international aid agencies often avoid engaging with the Centre in other public goods' domains, instead choosing to provide funding for public goods through NGOs and CSOs. Of the two international donors who provided funds directly to the Centre for education, one of them

⁴² Nooruddin and Simmons argue that this international aid is used to buy off the domestic "losers" as trade openness takes place (2009). This is a reasonable justification for why international agencies choose to donate, but most other measures of social development have not shown similar improvement, suggesting that something unique is taking place with aid for education (Paul et al., 2004).

⁴³ The DFID shifted their approach to funding in the late 1990s to one in which centrally-sponsored schemes were funded. Similarly, the Asian Development Bank recently authorized a loan for 94 million USD, with identified stakeholders as all being government officials. This stands in marked contrast to other international aid projects which require NGO participation.

(the Asian Development Bank) has taken a different approach to healthcare, instead funding hospitals and medical centers directly (ADB 2002). While comparing changes in domestic political support for education with domestic political support for other redistributive measures is beyond the scope of this paper, it is entirely plausible that different patterns of international aid have led to different outcomes in support for education versus healthcare, and for Centre-level education and healthcare spending. While it is clear that international influence has affected Indian government officials' support for mass education, only a closer investigation will reveal when international aid successfully influences domestic political leaders and when it does not.

In conclusion, Myron Weiner's *The Child and the State in India* was written at a turning-point in India's history. Weiner was correct in recognizing that education would not improve without a change in Centre-level government support, but this support materialized over the previous two decades. Not surprisingly, education measures have shown considerable improvement since 1991. But in 2011, the Indian education system still falls well short of realizing its full potential. Reports of embezzlement and teacher absenteeism are widespread throughout the country and literacy is still well below the global average of 84%. India clearly still has a long ways to go. However, diagnosing and fixing the Indian education problem in 2011 is not as daunting of a mission as it was in Weiner's day. Top-level resistance to education has abated, and the biggest remaining hurdles seem to fester at the state and local levels of government. However, reforming state- and local-level education is not a problem that the Centre will solve by simply throwing money around: depending on the problems, it is probably going to require careful institutional re-design and planning. Nevertheless, such issues are definitely surmountable, especially when one considers how far Indian education has come along. The future for the Child in India looks promising.

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